

Finding People in Floodwater from the Air

A three-drone search system, the flaw we found in it,
and what it will take to finish

Swastik Kumar

Department of Electronics & Communication Engineering
Thapar Institute of Engineering & Technology

August 22, 2026

1. Executive summary

Floods displace millions of people in India every year. The slow part of a rescue is usually not reaching survivors — it is *finding* them.

We are building three one-metre, 6.4 kg multirotor aircraft that fly a search pattern over flooded ground, recognise people from the air, report their coordinates, and drop a small relief kit to each. Everything has to be decided on a computer small enough to fly, without any phone or internet connection.

Most of the design is settled and its arithmetic is written down and reproducible. But while checking it we found a real flaw: **our camera sees a survivor clearly, and our own software throws that detail away before the detector looks at it.** We have a fix, and we can test it on free public data before committing to anything.

This document explains the flaw, the fix, and what the whole programme needs — **INR 7,34,379 across seven small steps**, each released only when the previous one has produced a result. The first decision is INR 31,371.

2. Problem

We are discarding resolution we already paid for.

A person in floodwater shows only their head and shoulders — roughly 40 cm across. Our camera, flying at 60 m, resolves that across about 26 pixels. But detection models take a fixed, small input, so the picture is shrunk to fit. After shrinking, the person occupies about **13 pixels**.

At that size, published results for detecting tiny people report accuracy between 29 % and 61 %. That is not good enough when a missed person is a missed rescue. And the obvious response — use a smaller, faster model — makes it *worse*, because smaller models take smaller inputs.

Three further things make floods harder than they first appear:

- **No suitable training data exists.** Flood datasets label buildings and water damage, not people. Datasets of people in water are open sea: clear blue water, no debris, no rooftops.
- **Thermal cameras do not rescue us.** In water, skin cools toward water temperature and the heat difference largely disappears. Thermal helps on rooftops and fails in exactly the case we care most about.
- **We were sizing for the wrong target.** Our early work assumed a person lying flat, 1.7 m long, rather than a person in water, 0.4 m across. That made the problem look four times easier than it is. We found the mistake ourselves — and it is precisely why we now want to measure rather than assume.

3. Solution

Three changes, in order of how much they help.

1. Fly lower. Coming down from 60 m to 30 m more than triples how large a person appears. It costs a little flying time, and we have a great deal to spare — the planned mission takes under eight minutes.

2. Stop shrinking the picture. Instead, cut the full-resolution image into overlapping tiles and examine each one properly. This is well established practice. The catch is that it costs four times the computing power.

3. Make step 2 affordable with a cheap first look. Most of a flooded area is empty water. A small, fast model checks each tile and asks only “*could there be anything here?*” The expensive detector then runs only where the answer is yes. We calculate that about **87 % of tiles are empty**, and we need to skip **80 %** to break even — so the arithmetic closes.

Steps 1 and 2 together take a person from **13 pixels to 52** — **sixteen times the area** — for the same computing cost.

The honest risk. The cheap first look might discard a tile that had a person in it. That failure is silent from the air and cannot be undone later. This is exactly why we intend to test it before adopting it, and why our pass mark assumes the pessimistic case: that such mistakes repeat from frame to frame rather than cancelling out.

4. Deliverables

1. **Three working aircraft**, flown as a coordinated group under one operator, with no phone or internet dependency.
2. **A clear yes or no on the detection method**, judged against a threshold we wrote down *before* running anything: skip at least 80.5 % of tiles while still finding at least 90 % of people.
3. **A measured detection figure** to replace the calculated one we rely on today. It would be the first real number we have.
4. **An evidence-based answer on flight altitude**, which our own design currently leaves unsettled between 60 m and 40 m.
5. **A possible publication.** Three research areas — image tiling, aerial person detection, and low-power onboard processing — have not been combined for flood conditions. That is a narrow, defensible contribution, and it is testable rather than merely argued.
6. **Code, data and results published either way.** A negative result still settles an open question and costs the same to obtain.

5. Resources needed

Money is not needed in one decision, or even in four. The programme splits into **seven small steps**, and the order is engineering rather than accounting: prove the motor before buying twelve of them, fly one aircraft before building three.

Each step is released only when the previous one has produced a result, so the department is never committed to more than one step at a time — and the first decision is INR 31,371, not INR 7,34,379.

All prices are current Indian retail. Totals include customs duty, GST and 15 % contingency where they apply.

#	Step	INR	Released only when
1	Prove the propulsion	31,371	On approval
2	Aircraft one: avionics and sensing	1,05,172	Measured thrust ≥ 3.18 kgf per motor
3	Aircraft one: airframe and power	89,192	Avionics powered and communicating on the bench
4	Fly aircraft one	42,574	Airframe assembled and weighed
5	Ground station and registration	66,992	First flight completed
6	Aircraft two	1,99,539	Aircraft one has flown a full mission
7	Aircraft three	1,99,539	Two aircraft flying with verified separation
Total		7,34,379	

Step 1 — Prove the propulsion INR 31,371

The smallest step, and the one that decides everything after it. Our motors are sold without a published thrust curve, so we do not yet know that the aircraft can lift itself. Rather than buy twelve on faith, we buy *one* and measure.

Item	Model	Qty	Total	Why
Calibrated scale	Bench scale, 30 kg $\times$ 1 g, certified	1	12,000	Mass is a hard limit; we cannot argue with a scale we do not own
Thrust stand	20 kg load cell + HX711 + power meter, frame built in-house	1	8,000	The instrument that answers the question
Motor	Tarot TL96020, 5008 / 340 KV	1	4,500	One, not twelve. Must lift 3.18 kgf

If this step fails, the programme stops here having spent INR 31,371 — and both instruments remain useful departmental equipment.

Step 2 — Aircraft one: avionics and sensing INR 1,05,172

Item	Model	Qty	Total	Why
Flight controller	Holybro Pixhawk 6C Mini	1	22,600	Dual sensors, industry standard, open-source autopilot
GNSS receiver	Centimetre-accurate (RTK)	1	18,000	Position accuracy is the largest single error in the system
Camera + lens	Arducam IMX477 + 6 mm, fixed focus	1	11,100	Fixed focus is correct at every altitude we fly
AI accelerator	Raspberry Pi AI HAT+ (Hailo-8)	1	11,000	Runs the detector on board
Radio + storage	ExpressLRS 2.4 GHz	1	8,500	One link carries control <i>and</i> telemetry
Onboard computer	Raspberry Pi 5, 8 GB	1	8,000	The host everything runs on
Mesh radio	5.8 GHz + antennas	1	6,000	Video and data between aircraft

Step 3 — Aircraft one: airframe and power INR 89,192

Item	Model	Qty	Total	Why
Motors	Tarot TL96020, remaining three	3	13,500	Bought only after step 1 proved the first one
Airframe	25 × 23 mm carbon tube (Kinenco Kaman) + machined clamps	1	13,000	Fabricated in the institute machine shop
Battery cells	Molicel P45B 21700, 4500 mAh	18	12,600	Peak draw is 38.3 A per cell; a 40 A cell has no margin
Pack assembly	6S 60 A BMS + power board + regulator	1	8,500	18 cells must be welded, fused and balanced
Speed controllers	50–60 A continuous, 6S	4	7,200	Peak is 29 A per motor
Payload release	4 metal-gear servos + mechanical detent	1	4,500	A power glitch must not drop a kit
Propellers	Tarot 1855 carbon, CW/CCW	4	4,000	See note below
Wiring	10 AWG silicone, XT90-S, JST-GH	1	2,400	Gauge is set by the 115 A peak
Propeller adapters	6 mm self-tightening hubs	4	1,400	A nut loosening at 5,000 rpm loses the aircraft

Step 4 — Fly aircraft one INR 42,574

Item	Model	Qty	Total	Why
Battery charger	ToolkitRC M6D , 500 W / 25 A, dual	2	11,672	See note below
Consumables	Fasteners, thread-lock, tape, filament	—	13,000	Consumed continuously; running out stops work
Safety-pilot radio	RadioMaster Boxer , ExpressLRS	1	6,955	A pilot taking over manually needs full-size sticks
Sun hood	Fabricated, plus a second-hand monitor	1	1,500	Screens are unreadable in Punjab daylight

Step 5 — Ground station and registration INR 66,992

Brought forward ahead of the second and third aircraft, because centimetre positioning has to be working before we can measure how accurately aircraft one reports a person's coordinates.

Item	Model	Qty	Total	Why
Field consumables	Cables, mounts, field spares	—	25,000	Corrections ride the existing radio, so no extra base radio
Base station	Second GNSS receiver on a tripod	1	18,000	Without it the aircraft have no corrections
Registration	Statutory, unmanned aircraft	3	5,000	At 6.36 kg these are Small category under the Drone Rules 2021
Survey tripod	Photographic tripod and adapter	1	4,000	Survey-grade is not required here

Steps 6 and 7 — Aircraft two and three INR 1,99,539 each

Identical to steps 2 and 3 combined, repeated once per aircraft. These are the two largest requests, and deliberately the last: by the time either is made, a complete aircraft has already flown the mission, so what is being funded is *replication of a proven design* rather than a hope.

Two notes on the parts

A saving worth having. The usual charger is the HOTA D6 Pro at INR 10,499–INR 13,500, but at 325 W per channel it can barely charge our packs. The ToolkitRC M6D is 500 W at INR 5,836 — cheaper and faster. It needs a separate power supply, which the department already owns. Two units give four channels, so the fleet charges at once on a flight day, and it still comes in INR 2,328 under budget.

One line is under-budgeted, and we would rather say so now. We carry INR 1,000 per propeller. The verified Indian listing is INR 3,250 per counter-rotating *pair*, so four propellers is INR 6,500 per aircraft rather than INR 4,000 — about INR 7,500 short across three aircraft, on the item most often broken in testing. We will look for a cheaper supplier first and absorb the rest from the charger saving and contingency; if neither works, this line has to rise.

What splitting this way costs

Smaller steps are not free. Buying one aircraft at a time means placing the same imported order three times, and imported parts take four to six weeks. Ordering all three sets together at step 2 would save roughly **eight to twelve weeks** of schedule, at the price of a much larger single decision.

We have chosen the smaller steps because we would rather move slowly with your confidence than quickly without it. If the schedule becomes the binding constraint, consolidating steps 2, 6 and 7 into one order is the lever — and it is your call, not ours.

For the detection test specifically, we need nothing beyond what the department already has: about **one week on a GPU** and **30 GB of storage**. The dataset is public and the software is open source.

6. Conclusion

The design is further along than it looks: the sizing, the error budgets and the flight software are written down, reproducible, and honest about which numbers are measured and which are still calculated.

What we are asking for is the means to finish it, released in four steps so that nothing is committed before the previous step has produced evidence. The immediate need is small — about a week of GPU time to test the detection idea on free public data.

We would rather find out now whether that idea holds than build on a figure we calculated but never measured. Having already found one sizing mistake that way, testing first seems clearly the better choice.

We would also value your guidance on four decisions that are ours to make but that we would rather not make alone: the body size we design against, the operating altitude, whether to adopt the two-stage detection approach, and which of two processing modules to buy.